
STUDY COMPANION

Golf Is Not a Game of Perfect

IMPORTANT INSIGHTS + ACTION GUIDE

Dr. Bob Rotella, with Bob Cullen

The Psychology of Excellence

A companion for review and action — what is most worth remembering and using.

The Central Question

When two golfers have nearly identical physical skill, why does one win majors while the other loses his card — and can the difference be learned?

The Author's Central Answer

At the top level golf is roughly ninety percent mental, and the mental side is a matter of choice, not talent or circumstance. Great golfers are ordinary people who have learned to think well and then go do extraordinary things. You choose how you think; that choice — shot after shot — breeds the confidence, trust, and focus that separate players.

The Framework: The Psychology of Excellence

Rotella's teaching forms a single chain. Each link depends on the one before it.

1	Dream	Carry a vivid, daylight goal. Great dreams make great things possible.
2	Choose	Decide in advance how you will think. You are not a puppet of your first few holes.
3	Train it & trust it	Build technique on the range, then trust it on the course and get out of your own way.
4	Accept imperfection	Golf is a game of mistakes. Respond to the bad shot instead of demanding perfection.
5	Compete	Beat the course and yourself first. Welcome nerves; hold your routine under pressure.

The Most Important Insights

Sixteen ideas at the heart of the book — grouped from mindset to mechanics to competition. For each: what it means, why it matters, the strongest example, what it changes in practice, and one line to remember.

INSIGHT 1

Thinking Is a Choice

Rotella rejects the idea that your state of mind is imposed on you by circumstances. How you think on the course is something you decide in advance and then repeat on every shot.

WHY IT MATTERS

If events control your thinking, your whole round is at the mercy of the first few holes. Deciding how to think puts you back in control of the one variable you can actually govern.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Nick Price's round used to hinge on his opening holes — a good start meant a low score, a poor start shattered his focus. Rotella told him he was letting the first holes jerk his strings like a puppet, and that he had to choose how to think before the round began.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You set your mindset on the first tee and defend it for eighteen holes, rather than letting the scorecard dictate your mood.

Remember: You are not a victim of the round. Choose how you think, then think that way on every shot.

INSIGHT 2

Confidence Is Built, Not Awarded

Confidence is not a reward that arrives after long stretches of perfect play. It is simply the aggregate of the thoughts you hold about yourself and your game — and at the shot level, it is nothing more than thinking about your ball going to the target.

WHY IT MATTERS

Players wait to feel confident before they play well, but that order is backwards — no one would ever win for the first time. Confidence has to come first, and it is available to anyone willing to choose the right thoughts.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Challenged on whether he'd bet his house on a forty-foot putt, Rotella said no — but explained that standing over the putt, nobody is asking him to bet, and he isn't thinking about averages. He is only thinking about the ball going in.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You stop waiting for proof and start each round already thinking confidently, judging confidence by your thoughts rather than by the last result.

Remember: Confidence is the sum of the thoughts you have about yourself. Choose it before you've earned it.

INSIGHT 3

Train It and Trust It

The golfer has two separate jobs. Train the physical technique on the practice range. Then, on the course, trust what you trained and let the swing happen — without a running commentary of mechanical instructions.

WHY IT MATTERS

The thinking mind that helps you build a swing is the same mind that ruins it under pressure. Once trained, the body already knows what to do; conscious mechanical thought only interferes.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Put a beam on the floor and anyone walks it easily, eyes on the far end. Raise it forty feet in the air and people start thinking about foot placement — and wobble. The task never changed; the thinking did.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Practice becomes the place for mechanics; the course becomes the place for target and trust only.

Remember: Train your technique fully, then trust it completely. Stay out of your own way.

INSIGHT 4

The Hot Streak Is the Real You

The magical stretch where everything clicks is not you playing over your head. It is a glimpse of your true capability, and it happens precisely because you stopped thinking and started trusting.

WHY IT MATTERS

If you believe the streak was a fluke, you'll wait passively for it to return. If you believe it was real, you'll reproduce the state of mind that caused it — on purpose, from the first tee.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

After shooting a fifty-nine, Chip Beck told Rotella, “I stayed out of my own way the whole day.” He let no doubt about his mechanics interfere; he had a plan for each shot and trusted his swing to execute it.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You walk onto the first tee already trusting, instead of waiting for a few putts to drop before you believe.

Remember: There is no playing over your head. The hot streak is your potential; manufacture it with trust.

INSIGHT 5

Aim at the Smallest Possible Target

Over the ball, don't think about mechanics — think about a target, and make it as small and specific as you can: a single leaf, a distant window, a spot on the green.

WHY IT MATTERS

A vague target produces a vague, uncommitted swing. A tiny, precise target gathers the mind, quiets mechanical thought, and steadies the stroke.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Told to aim at the palm trees behind a hidden green, Ben Hogan asked, “Which palm tree?” — not perfectionism, but a working principle: lock onto the smallest target available.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

Before every shot you name a specific, tiny target instead of aiming “down the middle.”

Remember: Before any shot, lock your eyes and mind onto the smallest possible target.

INSIGHT 6

The Preshot Routine Is Your Rod and Staff

A consistent preshot routine — the same physical and mental steps before every shot — is how you carry the trusting state of mind onto each swing and block out distraction.

WHY IT MATTERS

Under pressure, a drilled routine is the thing that doesn't desert you. It ensures a correct setup and keeps the conscious, doubting mind switched off at the moment of the swing.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

On the 18th tee at Pebble Beach in the 1992 U.S. Open — howling wind, ocean down the left, a first major on the line — Tom Kite ran his usual routine and striped a 280-yard drive down the middle. He went on to win.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You run the identical routine on every shot in practice and play, so it holds when it matters most.

Remember: A sound, repeatable preshot routine is the golfer's comfort in times of pressure.

INSIGHT 7

Golf Is Really Won Inside 120 Yards

Almost everything from the tee to about 120 yards out matters far less than the wedges, chips, and putts that follow. And the longer you hit it, the more the short game decides your score.

WHY IT MATTERS

Amateurs chase distance and admire ball-striking, pouring effort into the part of the game that influences the scorecard least. Scoring lives around and on the green.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Rotella told John Daly — one of the longest hitters alive — to work on his game from 120 yards and in. Even prodigious length scores through the wedges and the putter.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You shift the balance of your practice and attention toward the shots that actually make the score.

Remember: Learn to relish the short game. That is where scoring lives.

INSIGHT 8

Be Decisive, Not Correct

When preparing any shot, and above all a putt, commitment matters more than a perfect read. Pick a line, commit fully, and stroke it with conviction.

WHY IT MATTERS

A firm putt on a slightly wrong line often still falls or finishes close. A tentative, doubt-filled stroke on a perfect read usually misses. Attitude, not a magic stroke, makes a great putter.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Rotella traces this to his short-game teachers and states it as a rule: it is more important to be decisive than to be correct, particularly over a putt.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You stop second-guessing your read and start committing to a line and rolling it with conviction.

Remember: Decisiveness held with a good attitude beats accuracy riddled with doubt.

INSIGHT 9

Golf Is a Game of Mistakes

Golf is played by human beings, so it is a game of mistakes. The great player is not the one who avoids bad shots but the one who accepts them and gives full attention to the next shot.

WHY IT MATTERS

Demanding perfection on the course is deadly: the first flaw triggers self-blame that turns one bad shot into several. Accepting imperfection keeps a mistake to a single stroke.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Tom Kite told two college players the gap between him and them was four or five lost concentration shots a round — sixteen to twenty strokes a week, the difference between leading the tour and losing your card.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

A bad shot costs you one stroke and your composure stays intact, instead of snowballing into a double or triple bogey.

Remember: Strive for perfection in preparation, but never demand it on the course. Accept, and move on.

INSIGHT 10

Conservative Strategy, Cocky Swing

Choose your target and shot conservatively — a shot you're genuinely confident you can pull off — then swing at it with total aggression and trust.

WHY IT MATTERS

The deadly reverse is a bold strategy with a tentative swing: you attempt a shot you doubt, start steering instead of swinging, and produce disasters. Confidence in the choice frees the swing.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Arnold Palmer's famous drive of the 1st green at Cherry Hills in 1960 is remembered as proof that boldness wins — but in the first three rounds that same gamble cost him a par, a bogey, and a double. A conservative iron each day would likely have scored better.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You hit the shot you know you can hit — not the hero shot — and then commit to it fully.

Remember: Play a conservative strategy with a cocky, aggressive, trusting swing.

INSIGHT 11

Meet Fear by Swinging Freely

Fear (mental) is different from nervousness (physical, and often helpful). Fear makes you guide or steer the ball; the cure is to trust your swing and let it go as if you didn't care where it went.

WHY IT MATTERS

Swinging freely sends the ball straight; swinging carefully causes disasters. Once you've aligned and chosen a target, indifference to the outcome in that split second is what defeats fear.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Even Brad Faxon — a superb putter with an ideal temperament — developed a fear of his driver, seeing the ball fly wildly off line even in his sleep, until the fear wrecked his tee shots.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You separate nerves (welcome) from fear (steering), and answer fear with a free, committed release.

Remember: Nervousness can help you; fear makes you steer. Trust the swing and let it go.

INSIGHT 12

See the Shot First

Great golf is played first in the imagination. You vividly picture the shot — its flight, roll, and finish — and then let your trained swing reproduce the image.

WHY IT MATTERS

Imagination is fear's opposite. A clear inner picture crowds out doubt and gives the body a target to execute rather than a mistake to avoid.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Seve Ballesteros, in a slump, told Rotella that in his prime all he ever did was see himself winning and making the shots — he had lost not his swing but that vivid inner picture.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You rehearse each shot in your mind's eye before stepping in, instead of thinking about what could go wrong.

Remember: Imagine the shot fully, then trust the swing to produce what you've already seen.

INSIGHT 13

Play With a Game Plan

No serious round should be improvised. Decide in advance your target and club for each tee shot, the landing area on each green, the hazards to avoid, and your responses to weather.

WHY IT MATTERS

A plan lets you execute calm decisions made in advance rather than emotional ones in the heat of play, leaving your mind free on the course to do nothing but pick a target and trust the swing.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Rotella prepares players for the Masters by walking each hole backward — standing on the green and looking toward the tee reveals the architect's tricks and shows where the ball must land.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You arrive with a hole-by-hole plan and, when possible, build it by walking each hole backward.

Remember: Play every significant round with a plan made calmly, in advance.

INSIGHT 14

Choking Is Only a Lapse of Routine

A golfer chokes when he lets anger, doubt, or fear distract him before a shot, so he abandons his routine and game plan, turns the conscious mind back on, and gets tight and careful.

WHY IT MATTERS

Named plainly, choking loses its mystery. It is not a character flaw — it is a specific, preventable breakdown of routine and trust under distraction.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Jack Nicklaus told Rotella he wanted to be nervous — a sign of decline was not getting nervous often enough. Nerves are fuel; choking is only what happens if a distraction pulls you off your routine.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You treat nerves as readiness and guard your routine, rather than fearing the feeling of pressure.

Remember: Welcome nervousness. Choking is only the loss of your routine — so protect the routine.

INSIGHT 15

Ignore the Scoreboard; Play the Next Shot

Letting the score — or your own mental arithmetic about it — distract you pulls you into decisions you should never make. Stay in the present and play each shot on its own terms.

WHY IT MATTERS

The score is a story about the past and future; the only shot you can affect is the next one. Doing the math mid-round invites panic and reckless choices.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

At the 1939 U.S. Open, Sam Snead miscounted, thought he needed to gamble on the closing holes, went all out, and made a mess — throwing away an Open he had, in fact, already led.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You stop tallying your score mid-round and keep your attention on the shot in front of you.

Remember: The scoreboard is a distraction. Stay in the present and play the next shot.

INSIGHT 16

Your Real Opponents Are the Course and Yourself

The first opponent is the game itself — the course and the ball. The second is you: can you discipline your mind to shoot the lowest score your body can? Only then do other players matter.

WHY IT MATTERS

Fixating on rivals is wasted energy. If you win the battle with yourself, you've done everything within your power, whatever the result.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Asked why he'd share his coach with rivals, Tom Kite said there was more than enough out there for everyone, and they'd all help each other get better — and never let himself intensely dislike a player he might be paired with tomorrow.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You measure success by whether your mind was where it belonged on every shot, not by the leaderboard.

Remember: Beat the course and yourself first. That is all you can control.

INSIGHT 17

Quality of Practice Over Quantity

Working hard does not guarantee improvement, and the wrong practice can make you worse. The quality of practice — target, routine, and consequence on every ball — matters far more than the hours logged.

WHY IT MATTERS

Most range work grooves the aimless, mechanical habits a golfer should be shedding. Practice should rehearse the mind you'll use on the course, and weight time toward the scoring shots.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Paul Runyan, in his eighties, apologized to 800 pros for skipping his daily workout on just two days of the year — a picture of deliberate, honest, disciplined practice.

WHAT IT CHANGES IN PRACTICE

You practice with a target and full routine on every ball and spend more time on chipping and putting.

Remember: Practice quality, not quantity: target, routine, and consequence on every shot.

Key Definitions & Distinctions

Train it and trust it

Two separate jobs: build technique in practice, then trust it and let the swing happen on the course without conscious mechanical thought.

Confidence

The aggregate of the thoughts you hold about yourself and your game. At the shot level, simply thinking about your ball going to the target.

Fear vs. nervousness

Nervousness is physical (adrenaline, sweaty palms) and can help you. Fear is mental — the fear of a mistake — and makes you steer the ball instead of swinging freely.

Choking

Letting anger, doubt, or fear distract you before a shot so that you abandon your routine and game plan and get tight and careful. A preventable lapse, not a flaw.

Conservative strategy, cocky swing

Choose a shot you're confident you can hit (conservative), then swing at it aggressively and with full trust (cocky).

Selective memory

The deliberate habit of retaining your best shots and letting the poor ones fade, so confidence grows with experience.

The Action Guide

Eight practices drawn straight from the book. Each names what to do, when to use it, the problem it solves, what success looks like, and an important caution.

ACTION 1

Decide your thinking before the first tee

WHAT TO DO

Before you play, decide how you will think for the whole round — confident, present, one shot at a time — and commit to holding it regardless of results.

WHEN TO USE IT

Every competitive or meaningful round, set before you hit your opening drive.

PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Letting the opening holes dictate your mood and confidence for the rest of the day.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

Your mindset is the same on the 1st tee and after a bad hole; the scorecard no longer runs your head.

IMPORTANT CAUTION

You must renew the choice after every setback — one decision on the first tee isn't enough.

ACTION 2

Lock onto the smallest possible target

WHAT TO DO

On every shot, pick the smallest specific target you can find — a leaf, a window, a spot — and fix your mind on it instead of on mechanics.

WHEN TO USE IT

Before every full shot, chip, and putt, as part of your setup.

PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Vague aiming (“down the middle”) that produces a vague, uncommitted swing.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You can name your exact target on every shot, and your misses tighten.

IMPORTANT CAUTION

Pick the target during your routine, not over the ball — don't let it become another thought at the moment of the swing.

ACTION 3

Build and run one preshot routine

WHAT TO DO

Design a single, repeatable sequence of physical and mental steps and run it identically before every shot.

WHEN TO USE IT

Every shot, in practice and in play — especially under pressure.

PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Setups and mental states that vary shot to shot and collapse when it matters.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

Under pressure your routine runs automatically and your setup and focus stay constant.

IMPORTANT CAUTION

Keep it repeatable under stress; an elaborate routine is fragile. Practice it until it's automatic.

ACTION 4

Shift practice toward the scoring game

WHAT TO DO

Weight your practice time toward wedges, chipping, and putting, and treat each ball as a real shot with a target and full routine.

WHEN TO USE IT

Every practice session; rebalance away from mindless full-swing ball-beating.

PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Effort concentrated on the long game, which influences the score least, and aimless range reps.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

Your up-and-down rate and putting improve, and practice starts to transfer to the course.

IMPORTANT CAUTION

Learn to enjoy these shots — as ball-striking improves it gets harder to love the short game, and that's exactly when it matters most.

ACTION 5

Commit: decisive over correct

WHAT TO DO

Read the shot or putt, choose a line, and commit fully — then stroke it with conviction rather than hedging toward a ‘perfect’ read.

WHEN TO USE IT

Every putt and every shot where you feel yourself second-guessing.

PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Tentative, doubt-filled strokes that miss even on a good read.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You stroke committed putts on a clear line; even slight misreads finish close or drop.

IMPORTANT CAUTION

Commitment is not carelessness — do the read, then decide. Just don't keep re-deciding over the ball.

ACTION 6

Accept the bad shot, then play the next one

WHAT TO DO

Treat every mistake as a normal part of a game of mistakes: accept it, refuse the self-blame, and give your full attention to the next shot.

WHEN TO USE IT

Immediately after any poor shot, before you walk to the next one.

PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Anger and self-criticism that turn one bad shot into a string of them.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

A mistake costs one stroke; your composure and score stay intact.

IMPORTANT CAUTION

Acceptance on the course is not the same as never working to improve — strive for perfection in practice, accept imperfection in play.

ACTION 7

Play with a game plan (walk it backward)

WHAT TO DO

Before a serious round, plan each hole — tee target and club, green landing area, hazards to avoid — building the plan by mentally standing on each green and working back to the tee.

WHEN TO USE IT

Before any round that matters; ideally after a practice-round or scorecard review.

PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Improvising strategy hole by hole, which produces emotional, poor decisions.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

On the course your mind is free to pick a target and trust the swing, decisions already made.

IMPORTANT CAUTION

On an unseen course, use the scorecard, a caddie, or a member — even a tee-side plan beats no plan.

ACTION 8

Use nerves as fuel; guard the routine

WHAT TO DO

Reframe nervousness as the readiness of a competitor. When pressure rises, keep running your routine and game plan instead of fighting the feeling.

WHEN TO USE IT

Any high-pressure shot or situation — the tighter the moment, the more it matters.

PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Mistaking nerves for a warning sign, then abandoning routine and steering the ball (choking).

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You feel the nerves, keep your routine, and produce a normal, trusting swing under pressure.

IMPORTANT CAUTION

Don't try to eliminate nerves — even Nicklaus wanted them. Aim to keep the routine, not to feel calm.

Quick Reference — The Whole Book on One Page

- A person with great dreams can achieve great things. How you think is a choice.
- Confidence is the sum of your thoughts about yourself — build it before you've earned it.
- Train your technique on the range; trust it on the course. Stay out of your own way.
- The hot streak is your true capability, not a fluke. Start each round already trusting.
- Before every shot, lock onto the smallest possible target.
- Run one repeatable preshot routine — your comfort under pressure.
- Golf is won inside 120 yards. Love the short game.
- Over a putt, it's more important to be decisive than correct.
- Golf is a game of mistakes. Accept the bad shot; play the next one.
- Conservative strategy, cocky swing. Hit the shot you know you can hit.
- Meet fear by swinging freely, as if you didn't care where the ball went.
- See the shot in your imagination first, then let the swing produce it.
- Play every serious round with a plan — build it by walking each hole backward.
- Nerves are fuel; choking is a lapse of routine. Protect the routine.
- Ignore the scoreboard. Your opponents are the course and yourself.
- Quality of practice beats quantity: target, routine, and consequence on every ball.

Golf is not a game of perfect — and the golfers who accept that, and who choose their thinking on purpose, are ordinary people who go on to do extraordinary things.